

THE OPERATIONS RUNBOOKKIT

Four templates for turning work that lives in your head into work someone else can run

Every one of these came out of a real job — a law firm's intake, an executive's calendar, a construction coordinator's handover. They are deliberately tool-agnostic. The value was never the software; it was deciding who owns each step and what "done" means.

01 Client intake runbook

Seventeen steps from enquiry to open matter

03 Weekly calendar structure

Protecting the work only one person can do

02 SOP template

The structure that makes a process delegable

04 AI prompt workflows

Six prompts that survive repeated use

/CLIENT INTAKE RUNBOOK

Intake fails quietly. Nobody drops a client on purpose — an enquiry just goes unanswered while each person assumes someone else has it. This is the chain that stops that.

How to use it. Fill in Owner and Tool for your business. **Done when** is the column that matters: it is what turns a checklist into a system that moves without supervision.

	STEP	OWNER	TOOL	DONE WHEN
01	Log the enquiry and its source	...	...	Record exists, source attributed
02	Acknowledge within one business day	...	...	Reply sent and logged
03	Run the conflicts / suitability check	...	...	Result recorded, cleared or declined
04	Book the consultation	...	...	Invite accepted, prep time blocked
05	Send the intake form	...	...	Completed form received
06	Provision the client folder	...	...	Folder exists, named to convention
07	Verify the entity, if a company	...	...	Registry result saved
08	Confirm scope and fee basis	...	...	Scope written down, not discussed
09	Draft the engagement letter	...	...	Draft ready for review
10	Route for internal review	...	...	Reviewer has approved in writing
11	Send for signature	...	...	Signature request delivered
12	Chase signature on a set cadence	...	...	Signed, or marked stalled with a reason
13	Collect the deposit or retainer	...	...	Funds cleared and reconciled
14	File the executed documents	...	...	Signed copy stored, not in email
15	Convert enquiry to active matter	...	...	Live record created, enquiry closed
16	Send welcome, set expectations	...	...	Client knows who to contact and when
17	Create the first follow-up task	...	...	Dated task, named assignee

The one step people skip is 12. Every other step has an obvious owner and an obvious moment. Chasing has neither, so it becomes nobody's job — which is exactly why enquiries die there. Give it a named owner and a fixed cadence, and make **stalled** a state the system records rather than a thing someone eventually remembers.

/SOP TEMPLATE

Most written procedures fail for the same reason: they describe the happy path and stop. The person following it hits the first unusual case and improvises — and now you have two versions of the process. These seven fields are the minimum that survives contact with reality.

	FIELD	WHAT GOES IN IT
01	Purpose	One sentence on what this achieves and why it matters. If you cannot write it, the process may not be needed.
02	Owner	A named role, not a team. "Operations" owns nothing; a role does.
03	Trigger	What starts it. An event, a date, or a state change — never "when needed".
04	Steps	Numbered, one action each, in order. Name the tool and the destination. Write for someone doing it for the first time.
05	Exceptions	The two or three cases that actually recur, and what to do. This is the field that stops improvisation.
06	Handoff	Who receives the output, in what form, and how they know it is ready.
07	Review date	When this gets re-read. An SOP nobody revisits becomes a document people quietly ignore.

Three rules that decide whether anyone uses it

- **Write it while doing the task, not after.** Written from memory, you will omit the steps you no longer notice — and those are precisely the ones a new person needs.
- **Test it on someone who has never done it.** Watch without helping. Every question they ask is a missing line.
- **One process per document.** The moment an SOP covers two things, people stop reading to the part they need.

The test for whether a process is genuinely documented: could you take two weeks off without anyone calling you? If not, the process still lives in your head and the document is decoration.

/WEEKLY CALENDAR STRUCTURE

A calendar left to fill itself fills with other people's priorities, in the order they asked. The fix is to treat the week as a budget and spend some of it before anyone gets to ask. This is the structure I use to run a principal's week.

The five block types

	TYPE	RULE
01	Protected	Recurring, defended time for the admin that otherwise happens at night — inbox, invoicing, reporting. Booked like a meeting, because time not on the calendar is time others assume is free.
02	Buffer	Prep and travel as their own entries before anything external. A 1pm across town starts at 12:15.
03	Client	Anything with a paying party. Never scheduled back-to-back with another client block.
04	Internal	Team, vendor, admin. The category most safely moved when something has to give.
05	Deep work	The work only this person can do. If a week contains none, that is the finding — surface it.

Three things that belong at the top of the week

- **Availability bands.** Who is out, who is remote, who is working several hours ahead — visible before you schedule, not discovered afterwards.
- **Deadlines as fixtures.** Filing dates and deliverables sit in the all-day row from the moment they are known, so the days before them are visibly spoken for.
- **One unbooked hour.** Something always arrives. A week with no slack turns every surprise into a cancellation.

Colour-code by category, not by project. Category coding answers "what kind of week is this?" at a glance — too many meetings, no deep work, three client blocks with no buffers. Project coding looks organised and tells you nothing you can act on.

/AI PROMPT WORKFLOWS

These are the ones that survived repeated use. What separates them from the prompts people collect and never reopen: each has a fixed output shape. A prompt that returns something different every time cannot be built into a process.

Executive inbox triage

RUN DAILY • PASTE THE SUBJECT LINES AND SENDERS

Sort these emails into four groups and nothing else:

1. NEEDS A DECISION – only the executive can answer
2. DELEGATE – someone else can handle; name who
3. REPLY – routine, I can answer; draft one line
4. FILE – no action

For each, give the sender and a six-word summary.
If a message is ambiguous, put it in group 1 and say why.
Do not summarise the whole inbox. Do not add commentary.

Long thread to action items

WHEN A THREAD PASSES ~10 MESSAGES

Summarise this thread in three parts:

DECIDED – what was actually agreed, with who agreed it
OPEN – questions still unanswered
ACTIONS – owner, action, due date (write "unassigned" if unclear)

Quote the exact wording for anything involving money, dates or commitments. If something was implied but never confirmed, list it under OPEN rather than DECIDED.

Pre-meeting brief

RUN THE EVENING BEFORE

Write a one-page brief for this meeting.

WHO – each attendee, their role, our last interaction

PURPOSE – why this meeting exists in one sentence

OUTSTANDING – anything we owe them, or they owe us

LIKELY ASKS – two or three things they may raise

OPENING – a first line that gets to the point

Keep it under 250 words. If you do not know something, write "unknown" – do not infer it.

Monthly report narrative

FEED IT THE ACTUAL FIGURES

Write the narrative section of a monthly report from these numbers.

Three short paragraphs:

1. What moved and by how much
2. Why, where the data supports a reason
3. What to watch next month

Use only the figures given. Never estimate or fill gaps. If a number looks anomalous, say so rather than explaining it away. Plain language, no superlatives, no "leveraging" or "synergies".

Routine reply draft

FOR CORRESPONDENCE WITH A PREDICTABLE SHAPE

Draft a reply to this message.

Match the sender's register – formal if formal, brief if brief.

Answer every question asked, in the order asked.

State clearly what happens next and by when.

No filler openings. No "I hope this finds you well".

Under 150 words unless the questions genuinely need more.

Flag anything you are unsure about at the end under CHECK, outside the draft.

Prospect research brief

BEFORE A FIRST CONVERSATION

Research this company and write a briefing.

WHAT THEY DO — one sentence a non-expert would understand

SIZE AND STAGE — headcount, funding or revenue if public

RECENT — anything from the last 6 months worth referencing

WHY THEY MIGHT NEED US — two specific hypotheses, not generic ones

DO NOT SAY — anything sensitive, contested or awkward to raise

Cite a source for every factual claim. Where you cannot find something, write "not found" rather than guessing.

Why these hold up. Each one fixes the output shape, forbids invention, and says what to do with uncertainty.

That is what makes a prompt reusable by someone other than its author — and reusable by someone else is the only definition of a workflow that matters.

FINALLY

/ONE IDEA, FOUR TIMES

These templates look unrelated. They are the same argument.

An intake chain, an SOP, a calendar structure and a prompt library are all attempts to move knowledge out of one person's head and into something a team can run. The specific format barely matters. What matters is that each one names an owner, defines a trigger, and says what finished looks like.

The test is the same in every case: **could someone else do this correctly without asking you?** If yes, you have a system. If no, you have a habit — and a business that cannot function when you are unavailable.

Take these apart. Rename the columns, drop the steps that do not apply, add the ones your work needs. A template used exactly as written by someone else is usually the wrong template.

Built by Rafael Reyes — operations manager, and occasionally the person who builds the software when the spreadsheet stops coping. Case studies for the systems these came from are at rafaelreyes.dev. If something here is useful, or wrong, I would like to hear about it.